



istic fire effects in *Unreal 2* won't lag, and a DivX movie encoding will not take ages to complete, because of the memory subsystem. The AGP slot supports AGP-8X video cards, while the LAN connector can easily access broadband Internet. The onboard AC'97 sound plays six-channel audio. It provides support for future AMD processors, while the RAM can be upgraded to a whopping 3 GB using 4 DIMM slots.

RAM: Zion DDR 333/PC2700 256MBx2 SDRAM DIMMs

Price: Rs 4,900

Why we chose this: The DDR 333 RAM is the most viable option for a good quality high clock-speed RAM. DDR 266 is run-of-the mill, while DDR 400 is mighty expensive and difficult to obtain. DDR 333 RAM is already widespread, and it's just a matter of time before it becomes the norm. It gives better performance while playing games, and also provides an extra bit of power when working with resource-hungry applications such as Adobe Photoshop.

Hard Drive: Samsung SP0802N 80 GB

Price: Rs 4,900

Why we chose this: Samsung's 80 GB hard drive provides the space we needed for our applications, movies, songs, etc. The 7,200-rpm syncs effortlessly with the graphics card and the memory subsystem. It meant fast application load times and a decent data access rate—all for Rs 4,900 with a 3-year warranty. And yeah, it also has service centres strewn all over the country.

Graphics Accelerator: Gigabyte Radeon 9600 PRO 128MB

Price: Rs 14,100

Why we chose this: Firstly, because it supports DirectX 9 (okay, we admit we



were building this one solely for gaming). A major chunk of the budget was allotted to the graphics card because watching DVDs, playing games, 3DSMax modelling—all require a video card that has ample memory and clock speed. High-end cards other than this

would have taken up half the budget allotted, while lower-end cards barely provide decent DX9 support. The Gigabyte Radeon 9600 PRO 128MB was the mid-level category winner in our previous issue, beating the nVidia GeForce FX 5600 cards.

Keyboard: Microsoft Multimedia Keyboard

Price: Rs 1,200

Why we chose this: The Microsoft Multimedia keyboard is a class apart from the standard equipment bundled with most PCs. It has multimedia keys, along with a host of shortcut keys that let you access e-mail, an instant messenger, Media Player, the My Documents folder, etc. The sturdy palm-rest can handle extended typing sessions with relative ease. At Rs 1,200, it was quite a deal.

Mouse: Microsoft Basic Optical Mouse

Price: Rs 725

Why we chose this: It looks nice, is easy-to-use and works on any surface except for glass. It doesn't need cleaning, and doesn't get stuck.

Monitor: LG Studioworks 700S

Price: Rs 6,900

Why we chose this: Any respectable computer today has to have a 17-inch monitor, and the LG 700S fits the bill perfectly, giving decent performance at an affordable price. It has a flat outer screen, with an anti-glare coating, and the clear OSD menu is easy to operate.

Speakers: Artis S880 4.1 speakers



Price: Rs 3,500

Why we chose this: A decent set of 6.1-channel speakers costs a lot. We chose the Artis S880 4.1 speakers that have four discrete channels, with the subwoofer. Although it isn't an earth-shaking speaker set, the sound is ample and tight enough for DVDs, mp3s and games. However, it does distort at higher levels. The bass is tight and punchy, while the highs and mid-ranges are handled reasonably well by the satellites.

The Upper class All Rounder

It's hard to be satisfied with your PC, when there's always an upgrade around the corner.

The Enthusiast Upgrade pack

Processor: Pentium 4 3.2 GHz

Motherboard: Intel D875PBZ

With the Pentium 4 EE and Athlon 64 FX yet to catch up with India, this is the obvious choice. More than an upgrade, this is a complete system makeover. The processor and the motherboard complement each other perfectly.

Graphics Accelerator: GeForce FX 5900 Ultra 256 MB DDRII

With the Radeon 9800 XT still to be released in India, this is the only card that has the raw muscle power to tear any game

that you throw at it to pieces. It's absolutely future-proof and costs the Earth!

While the above upgrades apply only to the rich and the famous, the following ones create a sense of brotherhood and equality.

RAM: Hynix DDR 400 256 MBx2

Price: Rs 6,700

This upgrade lets the system utilise the motherboards' DDR RAM speed, and enhance performance by at least 10 to 15 per cent.

Speakers: Creative Inspire 5.1

Price: Rs 6,200

These exploit the 5.1 processing the sound card already provides.